ALL THE CHIEF MINISTER'S MEN

Eknath Shinde's loyalists include a motley crew of old-timers and the coup plotters



SHRIKANT SHINDE

Shinde's son and second-term MP from Kalyan. The orthopaedic surgeon is an influential voice in Shinde's party and government



BHUSHAN GAGRANI

The career bureaucrat is additional chief secretary in charge of the CMO and has a reputation for efficiency



BRIJESH SINGH

The IPS officer was the Director General of Information and Public Relations (DGIPR) when Fadnavis was CM (2014-19) and was among his closest aides. Now, Singh, who was sidelined by the MVA regime, has made a comeback as principal secretary in the CMO



SACHIN JOSHI

Shinde's P.A. often serves as an intermediary between his boss and ministers and party functionaries. Joshi is involved in many of Shinde's political moves



KIRAN PAWASKAR

The ex-Sena labour union leader had earlier joined the NCP and was made an MLC. Now with Shinde and trying to make inroads into the white- and blue-collar unions controlled by the Thackeray faction



UDAY SAMANT

Industries minister and Ratnagiri MLA comes from a family with strong business ties



DEEPAK KESARKAR

Joined the Shiv Sena via the Congress and NCP and is close to Fadnavis. Was the spokesperson and media interface of the rebel camp during the coup. The MLA from Sawantwadi in Sindhudurg is the school education minister



ASHISH KULKARNI

The former Shiv Sena secretary has marked time in the MNS and Congress and is now with the BJP. Played a major behind-the-scenes role in Shinde's midnight coup. Is an OSD in the CMO and link between the two parties



PRABHAKAR KALE

Shinde's other P.A. accompanies his boss to all engagements. Has been with him since 2004. Played a major logistical role in the change of guard in 2022



BALAJI KHATGAONKAR

The promotee IAS officer is Shinde's personal secretary



SHAMBHURAJ DESAI

The excise minister and Patan MLA was among the first batch of rebel Sena MLAs who left for Surat and launched the rebellion against Thackeray. He is the guardian minister for Thane district, Shinde's home pitch

kwad says that while Bawankule had retracted his remarks, they would not settle for anything less than 135 seats in the assembly election. "Bawankule was not involved in the alliance talks. Commitments were given by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, home minister Amit Shah and Fadnavis," he added. Shinde is said to have Shah's support.

Senior journalist Abhay Deshpande says that while Shinde had managed to wrest the tag of the official Shiv Sena, he is yet to build his own political party. This has to be done before the municipal and local body elections, expected later this year, which is a big challenge. "He has good tuning with Fadnavis, but the BJP is in command as the larger political party," he notes.

A senior journalist from Thane, who has tracked Shinde's career since 1997, notes that many of the CM's adversaries made the mistake of underestimating him. "He has tremendous potential...he is a Maratha from western Maharashtra and is young. He thus has several factors going in his favour," he explains.

A senior leader from the rival Uddhav Sena notes that a 'disgruntled' Fadnavis could become Shinde's bane. "Fadnavis secured power at a relatively young age. During his tenure as CM, his challengers in the BJP and those seen as not being on good terms with him like then ministers Eknath Khadse, Pankaja Munde, Vinod Tawade and Prakash Mehta found themselves in controversies. They were sidelined or had to take a hiatus from electoral politics. The question is, can Shinde survive this jinx?" he asks. ■